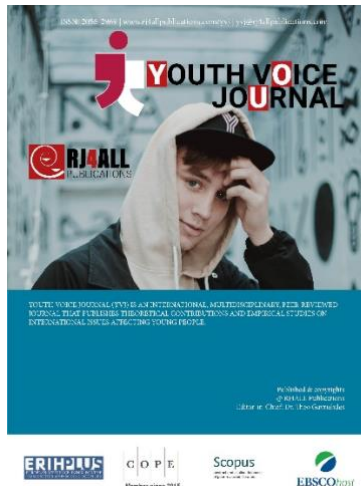




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Multicultural Education: A Reflection of Indian Classrooms

Dr. Vimal Singh

To cite this article: Singh, V. (2023). [Multicultural Education: A Reflection of Indian Classrooms](#), *Youth Voice Journal*, ISSN (online): 2969.

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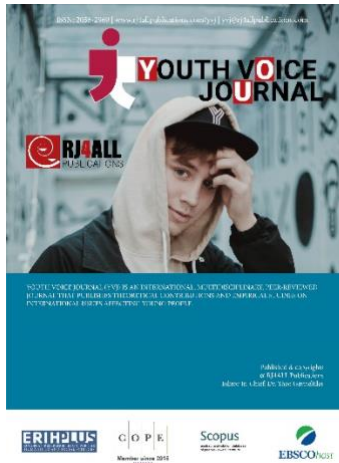
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British Library Cataloguing in Publication Data

ISSN (online): 2969



Multicultural Education: A Reflection of Indian Classrooms

Published in the *Youth Voice Journal*

www.rj4allpublications.com

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Publication date: October 2023

ISSN (online): 2056 – 2969

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Funding: This study is not funded by any National or International Body

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Dr. Singh have also been associated as a verified educator with the very popular and famous online learning platform Unacademy for 2 consecutive years and also developed e-content & uploaded his daily lectures on his own institutional Learning Management System; Gyan Sanchay.

Abstract

Purpose:

The education system plays an important role in inclusion because if diversity is seen the most, it is in Indian classrooms. So, it is a challenge as well as an opportunity that how we can support the future of India growing up in Indian classrooms and this is the main purpose of this article.

Design and Methodology:

The researcher has analysed reflective practices of Indian schools by conducting stage-wise relevant case studies with the help of case study design and also prepared a strategic framework under the qualitative paradigm of research.

Findings:

The main finding of this research paper is that, suggested different strategies for Multicultural Education play a very significant role in inclusive development.

Value:

India comes at number two in terms of population and 34.8 percent are youth. It is a reflection of our manpower and can play an important role in making India a global identity. This is possible only when their energy is channelized in the right direction to transform them into productive citizens. For this, it is very necessary that the inclusive concept should be realised by taking care of all their needs, which mainly include social, educational, and cultural.

This study is an effort for identifying core characteristics of multicultural education by establishing a conceptual understanding of Multi-cultural Education. It characterizes multicultural schools and suggests some very important arrangements for promoting multiculturalism in schools by using various physical and human resources.

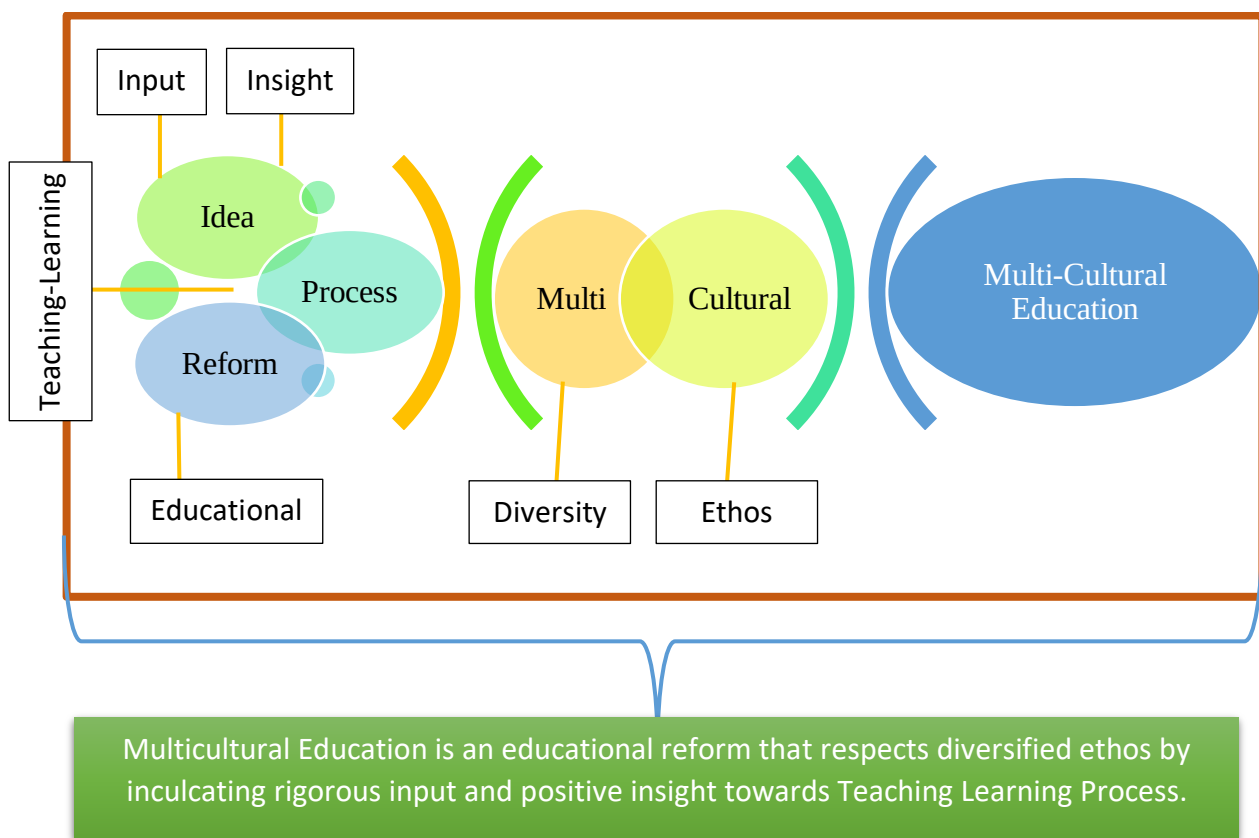
Keywords: Multicultural Education, Multicultural Schools, Reflective Practices, Strategic Framework, Inclusive Development

Introduction and Conceptual Establishment

There is a lot of diversity reflected in the culture and ethnicity of India. In spite of that Indian people are living in harmony and peace. They have owned very rich cultures, traditions, values, beliefs, etc.; sometimes they are very touchy with their culture and tradition. The culture of any society elasticities emotional sensitivity, cognitive nourishment, goal attainment motivation, and social and moral empowerment of the people. So that, the people will become productive citizens of India and ensure their active and productive contribution towards the fulfilment of individual and national goals. In the journey of the conceptual establishment of the term 'Multi-Cultural Education', an article titled 'Multicultural Education: Characteristics and Goals' written by J.A. Banks (1997) played a very significant role. According to Banks, J.A. (1997), "Multicultural education is an idea, an educational reform movement, and a process". Let us analyse three major terms given in this statement –

Flow Chart No – 01

Terminological Elaboration of Multi-Cultural Education



Former American President John Kennedy Said, “Peace is a daily, a weekly, a monthly process, of gradually changing opinions, slowly eroding old barriers, quietly building new structures” while talking about the importance of Multi-Cultural Education. Similarly, Martin Luther King Jr. dreamed of a nation where children will be judged by their abilities and skills not by their colour, gender, race, caste, creed, religion, etc.

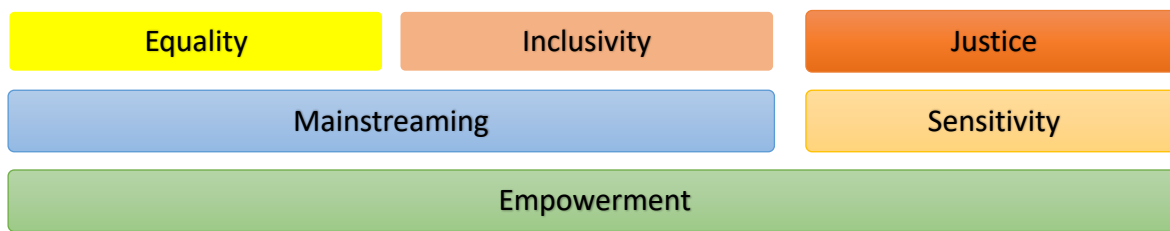
Therefore, this issue is not important from the Indian perspective even also a global concern. Inclusion is the only way that ensures integrated and inclusive development of all the classes of society. An important goal of Multicultural Education is equal opportunity for all students. There is a proper arrangement in Articles 14 and 21-A (Right to Education) of the Indian Constitution for providing equal opportunity to all students and promoting inclusive growth of the society. Chapter 22 of National Educational Policy 2020 also emphasizes on the promotion of Indian Languages, Arts, and Culture (Points 22.1, 22.4, 22.10, and 22.11). This includes closing the gap in academic achievement between mainstream students and students from underrepresented groups (Gollnick & Chinn, 2009).

In its historical background, multicultural education grew out of the Civil rights movement of 1960 and the call for equality and social justice for women and people of colour (Spring 2008). As a field, multicultural education includes issues related to social economic status ethnicity, and gender. Because social justice is one of the foundation values of this field. prejudice reduction, and equity pedagogy are core components of Multicultural Education (Banks, 2008). Prejudice Reduction refers to activities teachers can implement in the classroom to eliminate negative and stereotypical views of others. Equity Pedagogy refers to the modification of the teaching process to incorporate materials and learning strategies appropriate to both boys and girls and to various ethnic groups.

Now let us know about the key factors or characteristics of Multi-cultural Education reflected in the given Flow – Chart.

Flow Chart No – 02

Core Characteristics of Multi-cultural Education



As core characteristics reflected in Flow Chart No – 2, it is very necessary that these characteristics should be reflected in ground reality. Teachers should induce these characteristics in their pedagogical practices for ensuring equality in their classrooms and it also channelize students' calibre and capabilities (As a teacher is the First Pillar of the Educational Process). An inclusive environment should be provided by the School/College/University authorities for achieving maximum inclusive growth and development (Institution as the Second Pillar of the Educational Process).

Characterization of Multicultural School

James Banks (2008), a multi-cultural expert described what characterizes Multi-cultural Schools given below in the following table.

Table No – 01

Characterization of Multicultural School

Sl. No.	Major Components	Resource	Description	Arrangements
Categorization				
1.	Attitude, Belief, and Actions	Human Resources (Teaching & Non-Teaching Staff)	Human elements play a very important and significant role in enhancing cohesiveness among students by adapting attitudes, beliefs, and actions.	Group Dynamics, Focus Group Discussion, Synthesising Feelings and Emotions by organizing Interactive Session
2.	The Curriculum	Human Resources & Physical Resources	Multi-cultural education reforms the course of study so that students perceive events, concepts, and	Curriculum Enrichment Session by involving students,

			issues from the	Curriculum
			diverse views	Development workshop keeping in mind the diverse cultural needs of the students
3.	Instructional Materials	Physical Resources	In a Multicultural school, instructional materials represent the backgrounds and experiences of diverse ethnic and cultural views	Time to Time Text-Book Analysis, Content Analysis, Expert Content Validation
4.	The Counselling Programme	Human Resources & Physical Resources	A Multicultural school's counselling programme guides the student from diverse backgrounds toward effective career choices and helps students take the appropriate courses that will enable them to pursue these choices	Personal and Vocational Guidance Session, Organization of Non-Directive and Eclectic Approach of Counselling

Literature Review

It is an essential and important activity in the process of quantitative, qualitative, and mixed-method research after establishing the conceptual background of the study. Here are some very important studies that have been quoted for finding the research gaps related to this issue.

Many studies have been found on attitudes, beliefs, and perceptions in special reference to multicultural education with the use of various research approaches such as quantitative, qualitative, and mixed approaches. After the rigorous review and analysis of these studies, it has been found that courses promoting multiculturalism could improve the attitudes of the teachers (Akcaoglu, M. O., 2021) also have a positive attitude toward multicultural education (Debbag. M. & Fidan, M, 2020). Multicultural Education plays a significant role in improving the understanding of educators in terms of various components of culture (Doucette, B., Sanabria, A., Sheplak, A., & Aydin, H. 2021) and it also helps prospective teachers believe in the need for multicultural education and self-efficacy perceptions (Aslan, S., 2022). Few studies indicated that the use of Multicultural Literature, language teaching, and other related methods also helps in developing inclusivity within the classroom (Tangkitjaroenkun, T. Nawarat, N. & Jatuporn, O., 2022), (Kim. B. L., 2020), (Zamroni., Dwiningrum, S. I. A., Hope, J., Kartowagiran, B., Sudartinah, T., Siteine, A., & Yao, Z., 2021).

The researcher has gone through all these studies mentioned above and found that most of the studies have been done on attitudes, beliefs, and perceptions regarding multicultural education. There is no study has been found in the Indian context, especially regarding reflective practices of multicultural education to the best of researchers' knowledge and orientation. Therefore, this study is significant, relevant, and important for the promotion of the concept of Multicultural Education within the boundaries of the school and society as well.

Methodological Considerations

The nature of the present study naturally demands to investigate for identifying special cases i.e., schools, that are appropriate for multicultural educational practices. A deep continuous observation and documentation of selected acts and events pave the way to finding out major concerns of multicultural education. Further, these observations and analysis of reflective practices provide reasonable insight to

explore these major concerns based on sound qualitative evidence. These substantial descriptive analyses explicate the strategic framework appropriate for indigenous multicultural education.

Reflective Practices of Multicultural Schools

After the explanation of the characterization of Multicultural schools, now let us see some reflective practices of the teachers for promoting diversity and acceptance of others in their classrooms-

Table No – 02

Reflective Practices of a Multicultural School

Case No.	School & Grade	Case Description	Imaginary Name of the Teachers with their Respective Schools
1.	Elementary School (Early Childhood)	In all areas of my classroom, Multicultural books in several languages, posters, and other items – for example, garments, dolls, and music – that speak to diversity are displayed. The food served to children during meal and snack times comes from various cuisines and ethnic groups. At story time, books are read in different languages by parents and interpreted for the children to understand. Our philosophy is that we don't have to teach diversity, it already exists.	Mrs. Y School – A

2.	Primary (Grade V)	I teach the second grade integrated ESL (English as Second Language). At the beginning of the school year, as we are establishing our classroom community, we take time to recognize each student by creating a bulletin board with a poster of India at the centre. the display is entitled: “we are the children.....we are the world”. Each child's photo is taken and then displayed with the string designating his or her state of origin we use this map throughout the year as a springboard for many geography and Social Studies lessons as we explore and learn about India and each other’s cultural backgrounds.	Mrs. L School – B
Case No.	School & Grade	Case Description	Imaginary Name of the Teachers with their Respective Schools
3.	Junior High School (Grade VI-VIII)	I sometimes hear students call each other names in the halls and in the cafeteria. instead of ignoring this behaviour, I make sure I use these incidents as teaching moments and explain to the students why it is wrong to call each other names. I also use my classroom time to educate students on the beliefs and Customs of different religions and cultural groups. as I am the advisor of our school’s Unity club which celebrates the diversity within our school by a showcase in different cultures.	Mr. X School – C

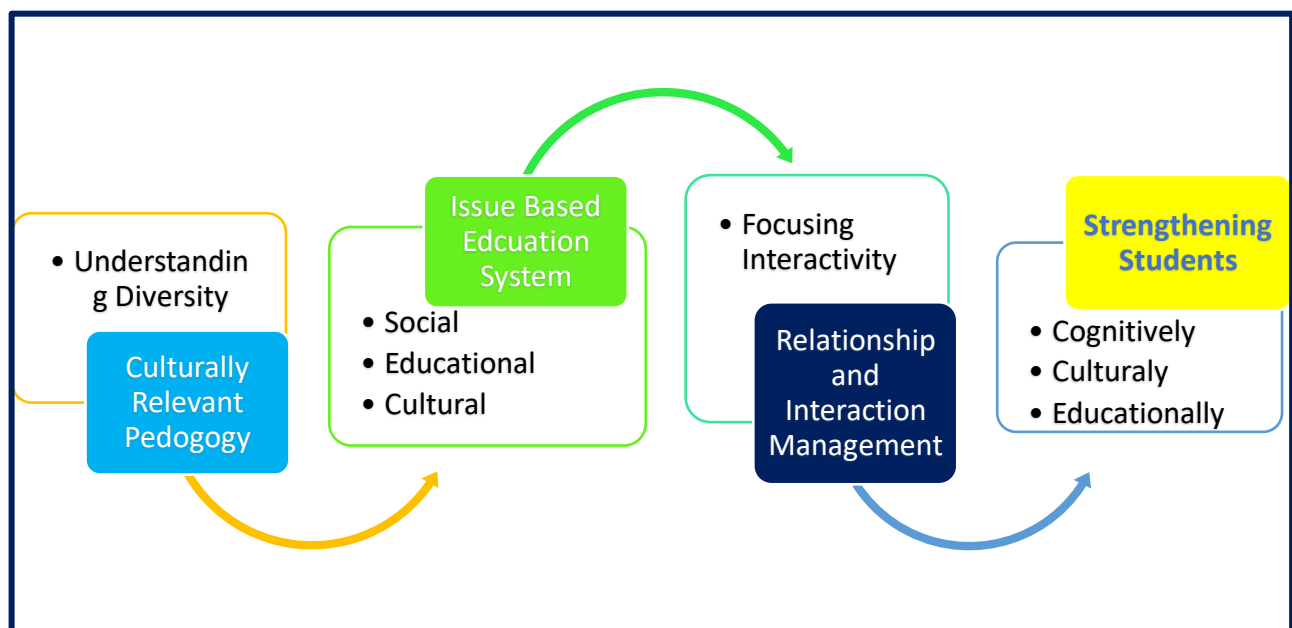
4.	Higher Secondary (Grade IX-XII)	About 50% population of my classroom belongs to different states of India and the remaining 50% of students belong to the state of Uttar Pradesh. As our teacher I present information on Indian art forms including pottery, quillwork, and black ash baskets. All students learn Various symbols colours directions related to these art forms. Every student makes some pieces, and each piece is unique which speaks to the diversity within the school	Mrs. Z School – D
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Major Concerns of Multi-cultural Education and Strategical Framework

As we see four cases of different grades from different schools, Teachers are trying to provide an inclusive environment to the students by applying inclusive pedagogical practices and instructional materials. Here are some major concerns of Multicultural Education analysed (based on above cases) by the researcher are reflected in the following Flow Chart-

Flow Chart No – 03

Major Concerns of Multi-cultural Education



There are four major concerns of Multicultural Education reflected in above chart and listed below with their explanations.

1. Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (CRP)

Culturally relevant pedagogical practices are the most important part of the whole Multicultural Educational Process and play a very significant role in understanding diversity (Gollnick & Chinn, 2009). With these pedagogical methods and practices, a teacher can make connections with the learner's cultural background (Pang, 2005). The experts in this field believe that teachers will be more impressive and effective by inculcating multicultural practices in their daily classroom practices (Manning & Baruth, 2009). One another aspect of culturally relevant pedagogy involves going into the community where parents live and work. There are some inferences or chief characteristics of Culturally Relevant Pedagogy: -

- i. Understanding Diversity among the students within the classroom
- ii. Building social relationships with students and with their parents by visiting their homes
- iii. Developing Social Abilities for enhancing Social Cohesiveness
- iv. Recognizing diverse needs of the students
- v. Give proper respect to feeling and emotions of each child while teaching
- vi. Connecting with Family, Community, and Society for elasticizing the calibre and capabilities of the students from different ethnic groups

2. Issue-Based Education System (IBE_s)

Issue based education system provides support to the teacher as well as school authorities for understanding different social educational and cultural issues. It is very important aspect of Multicultural education in terms of examining the issues regarding equity equality and social justice. Issue based education system is closely related to moral education. there are some cases which is easily available and reflected in daily classroom activities-

Table No – 02

Case Studies of Schools Promoting Multicultural Education

Case No – 1	Social Issue
'A' is a student in class 8 and he is very shy and conservative in nature. He has very less friends and finds some difficulty interacting with other students in the classroom. Because of this, the other students in his class tease him continuously and they don't want to be friend with 'A'. Now 'A' is facing Social-Boycott.	
Teacher's Role	
In this case, teacher should conduct Client-Centred Counselling (CCC) session with 'A' and try to find out the reasons behind his behaviour. A teacher could also meet with his parents (PM) and other family members for analysing his personality and social behaviour deeply. A Social Ability Development (SAD) Model may also be followed and implemented.	
Case No – 2	Cultural Issue
'B' is a tribal student of reputed school and studying in class 12th. She faces many difficulties during communicating and interacting with other students and class teacher because she is different in terms of language tradition values beliefs etc. With this cultural background she feels demotivation, demoralization, frustration and anxiety. In nutshell it affects her mental health. It is very difficult to accommodate with classroom environment for her.	
Teacher's Role	
A Language Proficiency Test (LPT) should be prepared and conducted for identifying core areas of language problem. A Personal Interaction Session (PAS) should also be incorporated for deeper understanding of her cultural hinderances and obstacles.	
Case No – 3	Educational Issue
'C' is not very much good in English speaking, writing and reading because English is not the first language of him. He is from rural background and he has completed his education from rural schools and colleges. He has not much exposure of various new innovative practices and paradigms in the field of education and communication. Therefore,	

sometimes he understands the content but not able to write and communicate with others. It affects his achievement in various subjects.

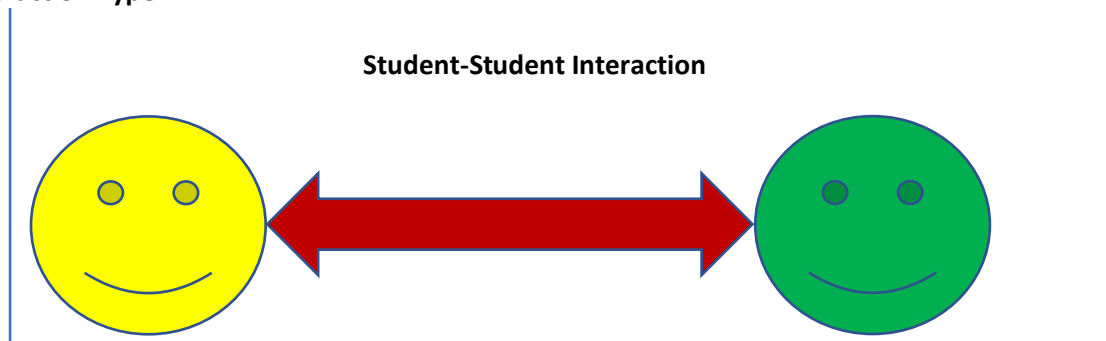
Teacher's Role

A Language Proficiency Test (LPT) should be conducted for identifying the loopholes of his communicative abilities. A Personal Guidance Programme (PGP), could be prepared for regular monitoring of his performance in the communication process.

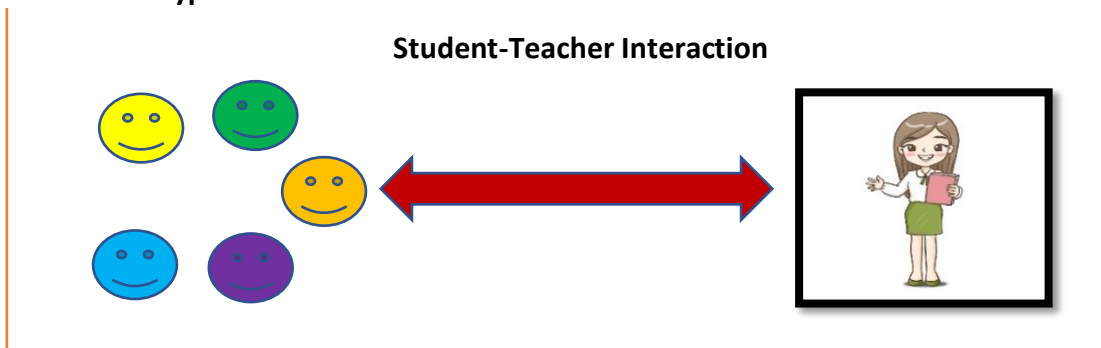
3. Relationship and Interaction Management (RIM)

There are a number of strategies and programs available for improving relationships. With the explanation of various strategies, it should also be knowing the types of interactions and relationships-

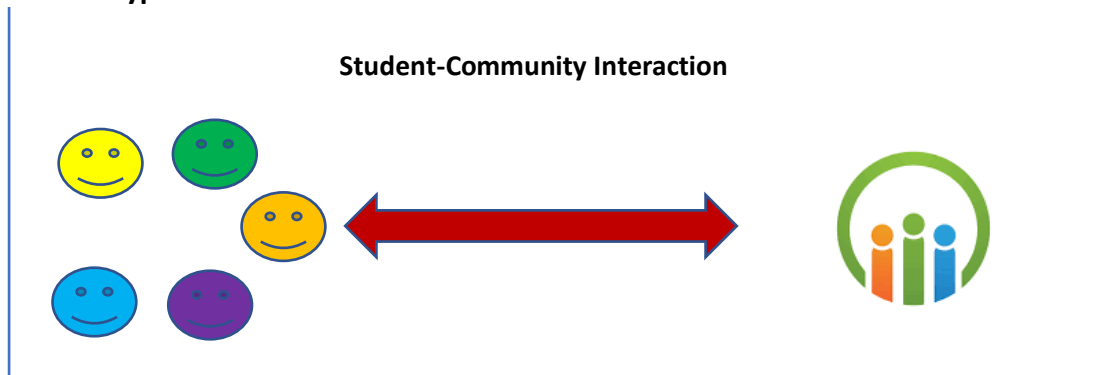
Interaction Type – I



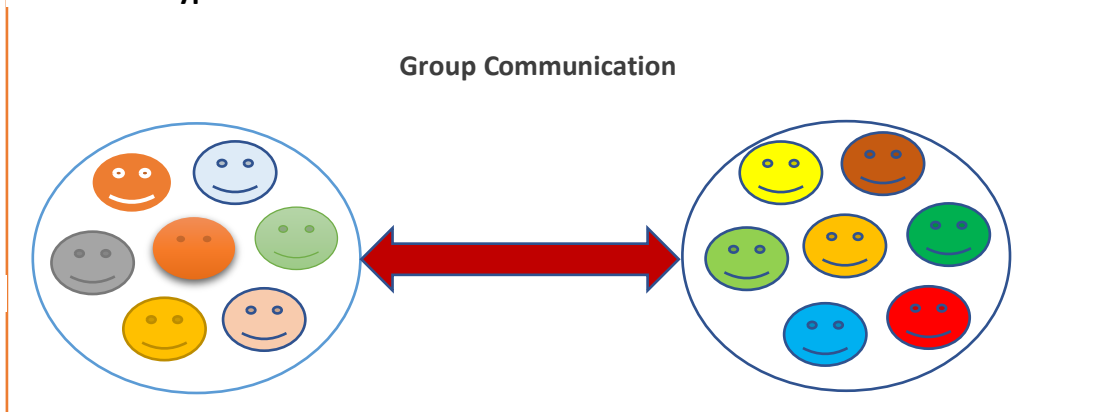
Interaction Type – II



Interaction Type – III



Interaction Type – IV



Strategies for Managing Interactions and Relationships

i. Interaction Type – I: Student – Student Interaction (S-S)

- Organization of Face-to-Face Interaction Programme (FFIP) for enhancing cultural understanding between the students
- Implementation of Individual Introduction Programme (IIP) for developing deeper mutual understanding

ii. Interaction Type – II: Student – Teacher Interaction (S-T)

- Preparation of Cultural Diversity Information Form (CDI) and incorporated on students for finding the social, cultural and educational needs of the students
- Organization of Personal Orientation Programme (POP), for recognizing the individual needs of the students

iii. Interaction Type – 3: Student – Community Interaction (S-C)

- Arrangement of Community Engagement Programmes like Awareness Campaigns, Social Support and Services, Community Services etc.
- Implementation of Community Interaction Programmes (CIP) time to time for knowing the community needs and aspirations

iv. Interaction Type – 4: Group Communication

- T-Group Training (TGT) Programmes should be organized for the betterment of communicative abilities.
- Social and Academic Interaction Programmes (SAIP) for nourishing the academic and social abilities of the students.
- Jigsaw Classroom: an another very important strategy developed by Aronson (1986) which involves having students from different cultural backgrounds cooperate by doing different parts of a project to reach a common goal.

4. Strengthening Students

Students could definitely be strengthened cognitively, culturally and educationally by applying and implementing above strategies; Culturally Relevant Pedagogy (CRP), Issue

Based Education (IBE) and Relationship and Interaction Management (RIM), in classroom practices.

Conclusion

The main focus of any system of governance is inclusive growth and development of the society. Indian classrooms are full of diversities. Only by adjusting to these diversities, the maximum development of the capabilities and abilities of the students coming from different cultures and backgrounds can be done. Therefore, it becomes extremely necessary that the use of special teaching methods should be ensured in Indian classrooms so that inclusivity, equality, social justice and social sensitivity can be nurtured. Multicultural Education is a powerful medium for this. In the presented research paper, covering different aspects of Multicultural Education, different strategies have been suggested which will definitely prove to be a milestone in inclusive development.

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